User Experience Report

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About the Project

Ephemeral Feeds is a browser-based endless-runner game that explores media literacy through interactive gameplay. The player character automatically moves across procedurally generated platforms, each representing a piece of news content. These platforms are categorized as either real or fake news, requiring players to make quick decisions about how to interact with them.
The core mechanic differentiates between normal landing and a “stomp” action. Players must stomp on fake news platforms to destroy them and earn points, while safely landing on real news platforms to progress.

Executive Summary

Across participants, the project was consistently praised for its creativity, visual design, and clarity of intent. Users described the game as “interesting,” “visually appealing,” and effective in conveying its message about fading information in current Internet.
However, user testing revealed several critical usability and engagement issues. Most notably, participants using high refresh rate devices reported inconsistent input responsiveness, including delayed jumps, missed inputs, and a “sticky” or unresponsive control feel. These issues significantly impacted playability and fairness.
In addition, onboarding and mechanic clarity presented challenges. Many users initially did not understand that fake news platforms required a stomp action, leading to repeated early failures and confusion. While the core concept was well received, participants also noted that the gameplay lacked depth, making it difficult to sustain engagement over longer play sessions.
Other issues included limited discoverability of interface elements (such as the About button), and a desire for broader accessibility features such as multilingual support and more diverse news sources.
Overall, while the project succeeds strongly in concept, aesthetic execution, and thematic clarity, improvements in input reliability, onboarding, and gameplay depth are necessary to create a more polished and engaging user experience.

Methodology

After the prototype was completed, users were asked to interact with the game in an observational usability study. Participants were selected from the target demographic of students familiar with web-based interactive experiences.
Testing sessions were conducted in real time, with participants encouraged to think aloud while playing. Users interacted with the game across different devices, including desktops and mobile devices. This allowed for observation of both behavioral patterns and device-specific issues.
The data collected was qualitative in nature and included user actions, observed points of confusion or frustration, and verbal feedback during and after gameplay.

User Tasks

Participants are required to complete the following tasks:

- Launch the game and begin playing
- Engage in multiple rounds of gameplay
- Describe their understanding of the game mechanics
- Read the "About" page
- Provide feedback regarding usability, clarity, and the overall experience、

User 1

User demographic: 21-year-old Male (US)

Observations:

Did not understand the "stomp" mechanic during the initial playthrough.
Died multiple times due to accidentally stepping on "fakes."
Described the gameplay as interesting but "a bit chaotic."

User Feedback:

“I didn't know how to handle red platforms when I first started playing."

User 2

User demographic: 22-year-old Male (China)

Observations:

Using high-refresh-rate devices
Jump delays / Input failures
Perceived as having an "unfluid" feel

User Feedback:

“A bit stuttery/sticky; The small ball moves too fast; sometimes I press the jump button, but it doesn't jump.”

User 3

User demographic: 21-year-old Female (China)

Observations:

Really loved the visual design.
Thought the concept was quite novel.

User Feedback:

“Probably I won't play this for very long; the gameplay is a bit repetitive.”

User 4

User demographic: 35-year-old Male (China)

Observations:

Did not notice the "About" button.
This indicates that the information hierarchy within the UI is not sufficiently clear.

User Feedback:

“The idea is great, make the button bigger so I can read it, otherwise it will be meaningless.”

User 5

User demographic: 21-year-old Male (US)

Observations:

feels monotonous when playing the game.

somewhat boring.

cannot understand the news headlines displayed.

User Feedback:

“Add some multilingual support and news from multiple sources.”

Key Findings

1. The core concepts effectively convey the ephemeral nature of modern information.
Participants felt that the setting—characterized by collapsing platforms and constant motion—along with the overall web design, effectively reflected the real-world digital phenomenon of news being rapidly consumed and subsequently forgotten.

2. Input responsiveness issues significantly hindered usability on specific devices.
Users with high-refresh-rate screens reported frequent instances of missed or delayed inputs; this not only disrupted the rhythm of time-sensitive interactions but also diminished users' perception of the reliability of their operational control.

3. The design distinctions between "news" and "fake news" platforms were not intuitively clear.
Many participants initially failed to realize that interacting with "fake news" platforms required a deliberate "stomping" action; this led to confusion and resulted in repeated failures during the early stages of the game.

4. The gameplay lacked sufficient depth to sustain long-term engagement.
Although users found the core mechanics entertaining, the experience quickly became repetitive after a short period of play due to a lack of variety and progression content.

5. The visual design significantly enhanced initial appeal and thematic clarity.
Participants unanimously praised the interface for its aesthetic beauty; this not only helped convey the project's overall tone but also increased user tolerance for potential usability issues.

6. The visual hierarchy of interface elements was insufficient, resulting in poor discoverability of certain functions.
The "About" button, in particular, was frequently overlooked by users due to its diminutive size and lack of visual prominence.

7. Users expressed a desire for broader accessibility support and content diversity.
Participants suggested adding multi-language support and a wider variety of news sources to make the gaming experience more inclusive and enhance its global relevance.

8. Clearer onboarding mechanisms are needed to effectively convey core gameplay mechanics during the initial stages.
The existing introductory guidance was insufficient to help users understand how to properly interact with "fake news" platforms, leading to avoidable frustration during the opening phase of the game.

Integration of UX Laws

Jakob’s Law

Users approached the game with expectations based on familiar platformer interactions. The project intentionally disrupts these expectations by introducing a distinction between passive and active interaction with platforms. This distinction shows the conceptual goal of challenging habitual, low-effort engagement with information, but also contributes to initial confusion when not sufficiently scaffolded.

Hick’s Law

The simplicity of the interaction model supports rapid decision-making, mirroring the speed of information consumption in the attention economy. However, this same simplicity also limits the depth of engagement.

Aesthetic–Usability Effect

The visual design enhances the perceived coherence of the experience and reinforces its thematic intent. The large-scale background text and dynamic visual layers contribute to a sense of immersion in an information-rich environment, supporting the project’s critique of media saturation while also increasing user tolerance for interaction challenges.